

Audit Finds Meta Ran Political Ads From Government and Oireachtas Members Despite EU Shutdown

2 September 2026

An independent audit by The Problem Solving Association (TPSA), a Trinity College Dublin-aligned research group, has found that Meta ran 53 paid ads from 24 Irish political Facebook Pages after its EU-wide shutdown of political advertising took effect - including Pages belonging to Minister of State Alan Dillon TD, Michael Lowry TD, several other sitting TDs, a senator and an MEP.

TPSA checked 1,433 Facebook Pages: all major national party Pages, plus 1,421 belonging to individual TDs, senators, MEPs, councillors and election candidates across all parties and none. Of these, 24 Pages ran a combined 53 ads on or after 6 October 2025, the date Meta's EU shutdown took effect.

Meta removed 19 of the 53 ads - 18 under its Advertising Standards policy and one for a missing disclaimer - but only after they had already run. The remaining 34 were never flagged for removal, while none of the 53 ads were initially blocked from launching before going live.

The shutdown took effect 18 days before Ireland's presidential election, limiting paid political advertising in the campaign's final stretch. The policy applied across the EU and wasn't aimed at Ireland specifically.

A TPSA spokesperson said:

"This wasn't an EU-imposed ban. The EU introduced new transparency and targeting rules, and Meta elected to stop running political, electoral and social-issue ads across the EU altogether. Our audit shows the system built to enforce that doesn't work consistently. Michael Lowry's Page is the biggest single case - but 23 other political Pages got ads through too, including a sitting Minister of State."

Lowry's Page stands as the largest post-shutdown advertiser in the sweep, responsible for 11 of the 53 ads. Meta's own records categorise it as belonging to a "Politician," describe Lowry as TD for Tipperary, and show over €5,000 in past spend on political and social-issue ads since 2019. Four of his ads were removed, but not before racking up an estimated 30,000–38,000 combined views; one, live 3–7 June, drew 20,000–25,000 impressions on its own. The other seven ran their course unimpeded - among them ads on Templemore Garda College, the River Suir, the Dean Maxwell facility and HSE, and a multi-million-euro school investment; the Templemore Garda College ad was still active as of 1 September. Three near-identical ads about the school investment, launched the same day with the same text and image, were treated differently: two were removed, one after as little as six hours, while the third stayed up until at least 31 August.

"Meta has no excuse here. The Page was tagged as a politician's, described as belonging to a TD, and had years of political ad spend on record."

Minister of State Alan Dillon TD (Fine Gael, Mayo) ran an ad announcing the Western Rail Corridor funding decision on 26–27 November 2025; Meta removed it not for being political but for a missing disclaimer - the only enforcement recorded against his Page.

Other Oireachtas figures caught in the sweep include Sinn Féin's Johnny Guirke TD and Claire Kerrane TD, whose ads on the CLÁR scheme and an ambulance service were both removed, and Fine Gael's Micheál Carrigy TD. Ads from Fianna Fáil's Seán Ó Fearghaíl TD - the Dáil's former Ceann Comhairle - Independent Senator Sharon Keogan and Independent MEP Ciaran Mullooly ran without being flagged at all.

The research shows that the shutdown has failed to hold since it was first imposed. On 6 October 2025, the "Catherine Connolly for President" Page launched a campaign sign-up ad carrying a political disclaimer; Meta removed it, but only after it had run. Two councillors' Pages, Labour's John Walsh and Sinn Féin's Louis O'Hara, also launched ads that day; both were later taken down too. Fine Gael's Ian Nunoo launched three ads with identical text and image on the same day in October 2025 - two were removed, one wasn't. Independent Ireland councillor Bill Clear ran nine ads after the shutdown; only three were ever removed.



"That's the bigger problem here. Page after Page, the same kind of ads received varied treatments. Taking an ad down after thousands of people have already seen it doesn't undo the impact and in most of these cases, Meta didn't take it down at all. It chose to stop political advertising in the EU. It now needs to explain why its own system let so much of it through anyway."

TPSA ran the audit through 'Tracking Political Advertising Compliance', its ongoing project checking whether political ads online meet spending, funding and disclosure rules, and identifying gaps in platform enforcement.

"A system that relies on platforms policing themselves needs outside checking. It's not enough for a company to say it's switched something off; someone needs to test whether that's true."

Much of the content is standard constituency material: GAA results, birthday messages, clinic notices, rather than campaign advertising, and declared spend on most of the ads is modest, each under €100 on Meta's own figures. However, TPSA says that isn't the point:

"The Pages involved are all categorised by Meta as belonging to politicians, many with years of political-ad spend on record, and its systems let their ads through regardless."

The spokesperson concluded:

"TPSA is not suggesting any of the politicians named, their page administrators, or anyone paying for these ads, tried to get around Meta's rules. The issue we're raising is with how Meta's systems recognise, classify and enforce its own policy against political advertisers in the EU."

ENDS

Notes to editors

- Project: Tracking Political Advertising Compliance
- Run by: The Problem Solving Association
- Focus: Transparency and regulatory compliance in online political advertising
- Sources and images referenced in this release are attached separately.
- TPSA's project checks whether political ad spend, disclaimers and declared funding sources comply with the rules, and identifies gaps in how platforms enforce their own transparency systems. The audit covered the full public Meta Ad Library record for the Page IDs in TPSA's database of over 1,400 Pages, and checked every ad launched from those Pages since the shutdown.
- Party spread of the 24 Pages: 7 Fine Gael, 6 Sinn Féin, 3 Fianna Fáil, 3 Independent, 1 Independent Ireland, 1 Social Democrats, 1 Labour, one then-Social Democrats candidate, and the Catherine Connolly presidential campaign Page.
- A further 188 ads from 34 Pages were launched before the 6 October deadline and continued running into the shutdown period; these predate the cut-off and are not counted in the 53.
- All figures and enforcement statuses were captured from Meta's public systems on 1 September 2026; Meta's records can change after the fact.
- TPSA is calling on Meta to explain:
 - How ads from Pages it categorises as "Politician", including a sitting Minister of State, were able to run after its EU shutdown
 - Whether it checks advertiser identity and ad history before ads go live
 - Why four of Michael Lowry's ads reached up to 38,000 combined views before removal



- Why similar ads from the same Page were treated inconsistently What checks it ran on the advertiser/payer labels shown on these ads
- How many other political, electoral or social-issue ads have run in the EU since 6 October 2025 Whether it will share data with regulators and researchers on ads rejected before running versus those removed only after they'd already been shown

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